



**"If you can see it, you can be it,"
Billie Jean King likes to say.**

Jakub Mensik vividly recalls the first time he saw two Czech tennis giants in person. "Every year in my hometown of Prostějov, they had an exhibition with Tomas Berdych and Ivan Lendl. So all the little kids, 5, 6, 7 years old, had the opportunity to play one hour with them. I played with Berdych and took a lot of pictures with him," Mensik told Fabio Molle in a March 21, 2023 interview on *The Functional Tennis Podcast*.

Watching the Davis Cup on TV with his dad further inspired little Mensik to dream big. "Tomas Berdych and Radek Stepanek were like legends in our country because they won the Davis Cup twice," he said.

"Tomas was my tennis hero when I started, but my idol was Novak. When I started playing tennis, my goal, my dream was to be one of the best and win Grand Slams."

Mensik never had a chance to play 2010 Wimbledon finalist Berdych at a pro tournament because the former world No. 4 retired in 2019.

But he will never forget the

bittersweet circumstance that led to his meeting and playing Djokovic.

At the 2022 Australian Open junior event, with temperatures hitting 35°C (95°F) every day, Mensik won five matches, including a tough three-set semifinal.

Enervated but at the same exhilarated by the prospect of capturing a Grand Slam title, he battled for more than three hours in a gruelling final against No. 1 seeded American Bruno Kuzuhara.

"In the third set, I felt my arms and legs and whole body telling me to stop," Mensik said. "But it was the final, so I was pushing, pushing on. After 5-all, 5-6, my body was absolutely dead. I can't remember what happened then."

Mensik suffered a painful, full-body cramp, and after Kuzuhara mercifully closed out the marathon 7-6 (4), 6-7 (4), 7-5, Mensik lay face down on the court, looking moribund. He was taken off the court in a wheelchair.

Unbeknownst to him, Djokovic had watched his valiant performance. A week later, Mensik received a text

Checking in from Czechia: Jakub Mensik is one of the future stars from Czech Republic, following in the footsteps of Tomas Berdych and Ivan Lendl. But his idol has always been Novak Djokovic. GETTY IMAGES

message from his boyhood idol with a video of Djokovic talking to him. "I was shocked and didn't know what was happening, that he knows [of] me," Mensik recalled. "Unbelievable. Unbelievable."

The world No. 1 was looking for a practice partner and invited the 16-year-old Czech to Belgrade for two or three days. Mensik gladly accepted. "I met Nole. He's very nice. I felt he was my friend at that moment, and I can ask him whatever I want."

They spent each day together doing Djokovic's routine: warm-up, on-court practice, fitness session, everything. Mensik called it "my biggest experience and a big motivation. After this experience, I'm a better player and a better person. He acts like a monster on the court, but off the court, he's the nicest guy